

MATH 345 Skeleton Notes

Unit 2: Anatomy of a linear map

Section 2.5: Inverses and determinants

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Matrix invertibility and linear systems

In this section we finish the square-matrix version of the Unit 2 story. A square matrix is invertible exactly when it “does not forget any nonzero input direction” and “every output is reached once”. The inverse matrix gives the inverse map when it exists. The determinant, a fundamental quantity in linear algebra that we only briefly discuss in this course, gives a single-number test for invertibility.

Definition: Invertibility of Matrices

An $n \times n$ matrix A is called

nonsingular

, or

invertible

, if there exists an $n \times n$ ma-

trix B such that $AB = BA = I_n$. Such a B is called the

inverse

of A .

If no such B exists, A is called

singular

or

noninvertible.

Note

The inverse of a matrix mimics the reciprocal of a real number.

Activity

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 1 & 4 \end{bmatrix} \quad \text{and} \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 4 & -3 \\ -1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Compute both AB and BA , and make a conclusion using the language of inverses.

$$AB = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix} = I_2 \quad \text{and} \quad BA = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix} = I_2$$

Therefore, B is the inverse of A .

Fact

The inverse of a matrix, if it exists, is unique. Therefore, we can write A^{-1} for the inverse of A .

Fact

For $n \times n$ matrices A and B , if $AB = I_n$, then $BA = I_n$.

Activity

Does $A = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$ have an inverse?

Let's suppose A had an inverse $B = \begin{bmatrix} x & y \\ z & w \end{bmatrix}$.

Then:

$$AB = I_2$$
$$\begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} x & y \\ z & w \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

This gives us the system of linear equations in four unknowns:

$$\begin{array}{rclcl} 2x & & + & z & = 1 \\ & 2y & & + & w = 0 \\ 0x & & + & 0z & = 0 \\ & 0y & & + & 0w = 1 \end{array}$$

The last equation states that $0 = 1$, which is impossible.

Therefore, A cannot have an inverse. This means A is singular.

Theorem

If both A and B are nonsingular $n \times n$ matrices, then the matrix AB is

nonsingular and its inverse is $(AB)^{-1} = B^{-1}A^{-1}$.

Why is this true?

It suffices to calculate that $(AB)(B^{-1}A^{-1}) = I_n$ and $(B^{-1}A^{-1})(AB) = I_n$.
Firstly,

$$(AB)(B^{-1}A^{-1}) = A(BB^{-1})A^{-1} = AI_nA^{-1} = AA^{-1} = I_n.$$

Similarly,

$$(B^{-1}A^{-1})(AB) = B^{-1}(A^{-1}A)B = B^{-1}I_nB = B^{-1}B = I_n.$$

Fact: Follow Up Facts About Invertibility

- If $A_1, A_2, \dots, A_k$ are $n \times n$ invertible / nonsingular matrices, then $A_1A_2 \cdots A_k$ is invertible / nonsingular and

$$(A_1A_2 \cdots A_k)^{-1} = A_k^{-1} \cdots A_2^{-1}A_1^{-1}.$$

- If A is invertible/nonsingular, then A^{-1} is invertible/nonsingular and

$$(A^{-1})^{-1} = A.$$

- If A is invertible/nonsingular, then A^T is invertible/nonsingular and

$$(A^{-1})^T = (A^T)^{-1}.$$

Let $T = T_A : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ be a matrix transformation induced by the $n \times n$ matrix A . What does invertibility imply about the geometry of the transformation T_A ?

Consider $T' = T_{A^{-1}}$. What happens when we compose them?

Activity

Compute the composition of T and T' in both orders.

Let's examine the composition of T and T' :

$$\begin{aligned}T \circ T'(\mathbf{x}) &= T_A(T_{A^{-1}}(\mathbf{x})) \\&= T_A(A^{-1}\mathbf{x}) \\&= A(A^{-1}\mathbf{x}) \\&= (AA^{-1})\mathbf{x} \\&= I_n\mathbf{x} \\&= \mathbf{x}\end{aligned}$$

Similarly, for the reverse composition:

$$\begin{aligned}T' \circ T(\mathbf{x}) &= T_{A^{-1}}(T_A(\mathbf{x})) \\&= T_{A^{-1}}(A\mathbf{x}) \\&= A^{-1}(A\mathbf{x}) \\&= (A^{-1}A)\mathbf{x} \\&= I_n\mathbf{x} \\&= \mathbf{x}\end{aligned}$$

Definition

Given a matrix transformation $T : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$, if there exists a transformation $S : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ such that $S(T(\mathbf{x})) = T(S(\mathbf{x})) = \mathbf{x}$ for all $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^n$, we say that T has an inverse.

Theorem

Let $T : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ denote the matrix transformation induced by an $n \times n$ matrix A . Then:

1. A is invertible if and only if T has an inverse.
2. In this case, T has exactly one inverse (which we denote as T^{-1}), and $T^{-1} : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ is the transformation induced by the matrix A^{-1} .

In other words, $(T_A)^{-1} = T_{A^{-1}}$.

T and T^{-1} ‘reverse’ or ‘undo’ the action of each other.

Activity

Consider $T : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ given by reflection across the x -axis. Find the matrix representing this transformation, and find the inverse.

$$T \text{ is given by matrix } A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Since $A^2 = I_2$, A is its own inverse, so $T^{-1} = T$.

Theorem

The 2×2 matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$$

is invertible if and only if $ad - bc \neq 0$, in which case

$$A^{-1} = \frac{1}{ad - bc} \begin{bmatrix} d & -b \\ -c & a \end{bmatrix}$$

We define the

determinant of the matrix A to be the quantity $\det(A) = ad - bc$. Thus the matrix A is invertible if and only if its determinant is nonzero.

For now, $\det(A) = ad - bc$ is only the determinant of a 2×2 matrix. We will define determinants for larger square matrices later in this section.

Activity: Reading determinant checks in code

The following code computes determinants of two 2×2 matrices.

```
import numpy as np

A = np.array([
    [1., 1.],
    [0., 1.],
])

B = np.array([
    [1., 0.],
    [0., 0.],
])

detA = float(np.linalg.det(A))
detB = float(np.linalg.det(B))

detA, detB
```

Output:

```
(1.0, 0.0)
```

Activity: Reading determinant checks in code (continued)

1. Which matrix is invertible?
2. Which matrix forgets a nonzero input direction?
3. How does the determinant tell you?

The output says

$$\det(A) = 1, \quad \det(B) = 0.$$

Matrix A is invertible because its determinant is nonzero. Matrix B is singular because its determinant is zero.

The matrix B forgets the nonzero input direction

$$\begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix},$$

since

$$B \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}.$$

For a 2×2 matrix, a nonzero determinant means the matrix is invertible. A zero determinant means the matrix is singular and forgets some nonzero input direction.

Activity

Find the inverse of each matrix, if possible.

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} -2 & -3 \\ 4 & 6 \end{bmatrix}$$

$\det(A) = (-2)(6) - (-3)(4) = -12 - (-12) = 0$,
so A is not invertible.

Activity

Find the inverse of each matrix, if possible.

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 6 \\ 2 & 3 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\det(B) = (1)(3) - (6)(2) = 3 - 12 = -9 \neq 0,$$

so

$$B^{-1} = \frac{1}{-9} \begin{bmatrix} 3 & -6 \\ -2 & 1 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} -1/3 & 2/3 \\ 2/9 & -1/9 \end{bmatrix}.$$

If A is an $n \times n$ matrix, then the linear system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ is a system of n equations in n unknowns. Suppose A is nonsingular. How can we use A^{-1} to solve the system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$?

Activity

Solve the system using the inverse of A .

Multiply both sides of $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ by A^{-1} on the left:

$$\begin{aligned}
A\mathbf{x} &= \mathbf{b} \\
A^{-1}(A\mathbf{x}) &= A^{-1}\mathbf{b} \\
(A^{-1}A)\mathbf{x} &= A^{-1}\mathbf{b} \\
I_n\mathbf{x} &= A^{-1}\mathbf{b} \\
\mathbf{x} &= A^{-1}\mathbf{b}
\end{aligned}$$

Therefore, when A is nonsingular, $\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}\mathbf{b}$ is the solution to $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$.

Consequences:

- When A^{-1} exists, then $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has a unique solution.
- If A is invertible/nonsingular, then the *only* solution to the homogeneous system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ is $\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$.
- Put differently, an invertible square matrix forgets no nonzero input direction.

Activity

Suppose that

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix}, \quad A^{-1} = \begin{bmatrix} -2 & 1 \\ \frac{3}{2} & -\frac{1}{2} \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b} = \begin{bmatrix} 4 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{c} = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Use this information to calculate the following:

$$A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$$

$$\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}\mathbf{b} = \begin{bmatrix} -6 \\ 5 \end{bmatrix}$$

The Elimination Scratchpad

Activity

Suppose that

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix}, \quad A^{-1} = \begin{bmatrix} -2 & 1 \\ \frac{3}{2} & -\frac{1}{2} \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b} = \begin{bmatrix} 4 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{c} = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Use this information to calculate the following:

$$A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{c}$$

$$\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}\mathbf{c} = \begin{bmatrix} -4 \\ \frac{7}{2} \end{bmatrix}$$

The Elimination Scratchpad

Activity

Suppose that

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 4 \end{bmatrix}, \quad A^{-1} = \begin{bmatrix} -2 & 1 \\ \frac{3}{2} & -\frac{1}{2} \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b} = \begin{bmatrix} 4 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{c} = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Use this information to calculate the following:

$$A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$$

$$\mathbf{x} = A^{-1}\mathbf{0} = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

The Elimination Scratchpad

Activity

Consider the transformation $P : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ defined by

$$P\left(\begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{bmatrix}\right) = \begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Is P a matrix transformation? If so, find the matrix A corresponding to P .

Yes, P is a matrix transformation. It can be represented by the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

To verify:

$$P\left(\begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{bmatrix}\right) = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity

Consider the transformation $P : \mathbb{R}^2 \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^2$ defined by

$$P \left(\begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ a_2 \end{bmatrix} \right) = \begin{bmatrix} a_1 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Is P an invertible transformation?

No, P is not invertible. Note that $\det(A) = 0$, and so A is not an invertible matrix, and so P cannot be an invertible transformation.

Calculating inverses

Consider vectors $\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_n$ in $\mathbb{R}^m$, and let A be the $m \times n$ matrix whose columns are the vectors $\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_n$.

Note that $\{\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_n\}$ are linearly independent precisely when the equation $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has *only* the *trivial* solution.

Note that additionally, $\text{span}\{\mathbf{c}_1, \dots, \mathbf{c}_n\} = \mathbb{R}^m$ exactly when $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has a solution for all $\mathbf{b}$ in $\mathbb{R}^m$.

We use these facts to extend our invertibility criteria for matrices.

Fact: Invertibility Criteria

Let A be a $n \times n$ matrix. Then the following are equivalent:

- A is invertible.
- The columns of A are linearly independent.
- The columns of A span $\mathbb{R}^n$.
- The rows of A are linearly independent.

- The rows of A span $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Activity

Let $S = \{\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3\}$, where

$$\mathbf{v}_1 = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 2 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix} \quad \mathbf{v}_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ -1 \\ 2 \end{bmatrix} \quad \mathbf{v}_3 = \begin{bmatrix} 3 \\ 0 \\ -5 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Is S linearly dependent?

Put the vectors in the columns of a matrix:

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 2 & -1 & 0 \\ 2 & 2 & -5 \end{bmatrix}$$

The Elimination Scratchpad Use c_1, c_2, c_3 for the coefficients in $c_1\mathbf{v}_1 + c_2\mathbf{v}_2 + c_3\mathbf{v}_3 = \mathbf{0}$.

Row reduction gives

$$\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 2 & -1 & 0 \\ 2 & 2 & -5 \end{bmatrix} \sim \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 0 & -1 & -6 \\ 0 & 2 & -11 \end{bmatrix} \\ \sim \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 0 & 3 \\ 0 & -1 & -6 \\ 0 & 0 & -23 \end{bmatrix}.$$

This echelon form has a pivot in every column. Therefore the equation $Ac = 0$ has only the trivial solution, so no nontrivial linear combination of $\mathbf{v}_1, \mathbf{v}_2, \mathbf{v}_3$ gives zero. Thus S is linearly independent, not linearly dependent.

For a given $n \times n$ matrix A , if we are looking for an inverse for A (call this matrix X), we must have $AX = I_n$. We are solving n linear systems simultaneously:

Activity

Describe the system of linear equations for finding the inverse.

We need to solve these systems:

$$\begin{aligned} A \begin{bmatrix} x_{11} \\ x_{21} \\ \vdots \\ x_{n1} \end{bmatrix} &= \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \\ A \begin{bmatrix} x_{12} \\ x_{22} \\ \vdots \\ x_{n2} \end{bmatrix} &= \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \\ \vdots \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}, \\ &\dots, \\ A \begin{bmatrix} x_{1n} \\ x_{2n} \\ \vdots \\ x_{nn} \end{bmatrix} &= \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ \vdots \\ 1 \end{bmatrix} \end{aligned}$$

Since, to solve each system, we wish to reduce the matrix A down to its RREF each time, we can combine all the systems into one big augmented matrix:

Activity

Write the augmented matrix for finding the inverse.

$$[A \mid I_n] = \left[\begin{array}{cccc|cccc} a_{11} & a_{12} & \cdots & a_{1n} & 1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ a_{21} & a_{22} & \cdots & a_{2n} & 0 & 1 & \cdots & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots & \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ a_{n1} & a_{n2} & \cdots & a_{nn} & 0 & 0 & \cdots & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

It follows from the theorem that if $[A \mid I_n]$ is row reducible to $[B \mid C]$, then $BX = C$. In particular, if we can row reduce $[A \mid I_n]$ to $[I_n \mid C]$, then it follows that $X = C$. Gaussian elimination (The Gaussian Elimination Algorithm) will reduce a given matrix to this form, provided that an inverse exists.

1. Set up the augmented matrix $[A \mid I_n]$.
2. Apply elementary row operations to $[A \mid I_n]$ to reduce it to $[I_n \mid A^{-1}]$.

If A is an $n \times n$ matrix, either A can be reduced to I_n by elementary row operations or it cannot. In the first case, the algorithm produces A^{-1} ; in the second case, A^{-1} does not exist.

Activity

Find A^{-1} where $A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 & 4 \\ 2 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$.

Start with $[A \mid I_3]$:

$$[A \mid I_3] = \left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 1 & 4 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 2 & 3 & 2 & 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

Perform row operations:

$$R_2 \rightarrow R_2 - 2R_1$$

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 1 & 4 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -6 & -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

$$R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - R_2$$

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 10 & 3 & -1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 & -6 & -2 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

$$R_1 \rightarrow R_1 - 10R_3$$

$$R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + 6R_3$$

$$\left[\begin{array}{ccc|ccc} 1 & 0 & 0 & 3 & -1 & -10 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 & -2 & 1 & 6 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

Therefore:

$$A^{-1} = \left[\begin{array}{ccc} 3 & -1 & -10 \\ -2 & 1 & 6 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{array} \right]$$

Theorem: Box of Facts/Invertibility Criteria

Expanding on Invertibility Criteria, we can add row-reduction and solution-set criteria to the same list.

Let A be an $n \times n$ matrix. The following are equivalent:

1. A is nonsingular/invertible.
2. The columns of A are linearly independent.
3. The columns of A span $\mathbb{R}^n$.
4. The rows of A are linearly independent.
5. The rows of A span $\mathbb{R}^n$.
6. $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{0}$ has only the trivial solution.
7. A is row equivalent to I_n .
8. The linear system $A\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{b}$ has a unique solution for every $n \times 1$ matrix $\mathbf{b}$.

9. The rank of A is n .

General determinants

In this section we consider square $n \times n$ matrices. Our *goal* is to find a number, called the *determinant* that we can calculate for any matrix, which tells us whether or not the matrix is invertible.

Let's start with the 2×2 case. Recall that in the theorem we defined the determinant of a 2×2 matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$$

to be $\det(A) = ad - bc$. It has the required properties of the determinant that we will now define for more general matrices.

Activity

Find the determinant of the following matrices:

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ 4 & 2 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\det(A) = 3(2) - 1(4) = 6 - 4 = 2.$$

Activity

Find the determinant of the following matrices:

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 2 \\ 6 & 4 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\det(B) = 3(4) - 2(6) = 12 - 12 = 0.$$

We use the 2×2 determinant to define the 3×3 determinant. The idea is recursive: a 3×3 determinant is built from 2×2 determinants. Later, an $n \times n$ determinant will be built from $(n - 1) \times (n - 1)$ determinants.

Definition: Minors of a 3×3 matrix

Let A be a 3×3 matrix. The

(i, j) -th minor

of A , denoted

$$\text{minor}(A)_{ij},$$

is the determinant of the 2×2 matrix obtained from A by deleting row i and column j .

Activity

Suppose

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Calculate $\text{minor}(A)_{11}$.

$$\text{minor}(A)_{11} = \det \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 2 \\ 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix} = 3(1) - 2(2) = -1.$$

Activity

Suppose

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Calculate $\text{minor}(A)_{23}$.

$$\text{minor}(A)_{23} = \det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 \end{bmatrix} = 1(2) - 2(3) = -4.$$

Definition: Cofactors of a 3×3 matrix

Let A be a 3×3 matrix. The

(i, j) -cofactor

of A , denoted

$$\text{cof}(A)_{ij},$$

is

$$\text{cof}(A)_{ij} = (-1)^{i+j} \text{minor}(A)_{ij}.$$

Activity

Define

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Compute $\text{cof}(A)_{11}$.

$$\text{cof}(A)_{11} = (-1)^{1+1} \text{minor}(A)_{11} = (1)(-1) = -1.$$

Activity

Define

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Compute $\text{cof}(A)_{23}$.

$$\text{cof}(A)_{23} = (-1)^{2+3} \text{minor}(A)_{23} = (-1)(-4) = 4.$$

Definition: Determinant of a 3×3 matrix

Let $A = [a_{ij}]$ be a 3×3 matrix. The

determinant of A , denoted $\det(A)$, is defined by expansion along the first row:

$$\det(A) = a_{11} \text{cof}(A)_{11} + a_{12} \text{cof}(A)_{12} + a_{13} \text{cof}(A)_{13}.$$

This process is called

cofactor expansion.

Fact

For a 3×3 matrix, cofactor expansion along any row or any column gives the same determinant.

Activity

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Find the determinant of A by expanding along row 1.

To calculate the determinant of A by expanding along row 1, we write

$$\det(A) = 1 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{11} + 2 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{12} + 3 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{13}.$$

We begin by calculating the cofactors:

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{cof}(A)_{11} &= (-1)^{1+1} \det \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 2 \\ 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= (1)(3 \cdot 1 - 2 \cdot 2) = -1\end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{cof}(A)_{12} &= (-1)^{1+2} \det \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 2 \\ 3 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= (-1)(4 \cdot 1 - 2 \cdot 3) = 2\end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{cof}(A)_{13} &= (-1)^{1+3} \det \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 3 \\ 3 & 2 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= (1)(8 - 9) = -1\end{aligned}$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned}\det(A) &= 1(-1) + 2(2) + 3(-1) \\ &= -1 + 4 - 3 = 0.\end{aligned}$$

Activity

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 4 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & 2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Find the determinant of A by expanding along column 2.

To calculate the determinant of A by expanding along column 2, we write

$$\det(A) = 2 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{12} + 3 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{22} + 2 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{32}$$

We calculate the cofactors:

$$\begin{aligned}\operatorname{cof}(A)_{12} &= (-1)^{1+2} \det \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 2 \\ 3 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= (-1)(4 \cdot 1 - 2 \cdot 3) = 2\end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}\text{cof}(A)_{22} &= (-1)^{2+2} \det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= (1)(1 \cdot 1 - 3 \cdot 3) = -8\end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}\text{cof}(A)_{32} &= (-1)^{3+2} \det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 3 \\ 4 & 2 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= (-1)(2 - 12) = 10.\end{aligned}$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned}\det(A) &= 2(2) + 3(-8) + 2(10) \\ &= 4 - 24 + 20 = 0.\end{aligned}$$

Note

To track the sign $(-1)^{i+j}$ when computing cofactors, it may be helpful to view the matrix as a checkerboard as below:

$$\begin{bmatrix} + & - & + \\ - & + & - \\ + & - & + \end{bmatrix}$$

The sign in the i th row and j th position will be the sign of $(-1)^{i+j}$.

Note

Since any row or column gives the same determinant, choose a row or column with many zeros when possible.

Activity

Compute the determinant of the following matrices:

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & -5 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ -2 & -4 & 7 \end{bmatrix}$$

The second row of A has two zeros, and so expanding along this row will likely result in the simplest computation of the determinant. We write

$$\begin{aligned} \det(A) &= 0 \cdot \text{cof}(A)_{21} + 1 \cdot \text{cof}(A)_{22} + 0 \cdot \text{cof}(A)_{23} \\ &= \text{cof}(A)_{22} \\ &= (-1)^{2+2} \det \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ -2 & 7 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= (1)(3 \cdot 7 - 1 \cdot (-2)) \\ &= 21 + 2 = 23. \end{aligned}$$

Activity

Compute the determinant of the following matrices:

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & \pi & 200 \\ 0 & 0.03 & 4 \\ 0 & 19 & -3584 \end{bmatrix}$$

If we expand the determinant of B along its first column, we find that

$$\begin{aligned} \det(B) &= 0 \cdot \text{cof}(B)_{11} \\ &\quad + 0 \cdot \text{cof}(B)_{21} \\ &\quad + 0 \cdot \text{cof}(B)_{31} \\ &= 0. \end{aligned}$$

Note

Whenever a row or column of a matrix only has zeros as entries, expanding along that row shows that the determinant of the matrix is always zero, so no cofactor computations are required.

Now that 3×3 determinants have been defined, we can define larger determinants recursively. For a 4×4 matrix, each minor determinant is a 3×3 determinant. For a 5×5 matrix, each minor determinant is a 4×4 determinant, and so on.

Definition: Determinant of a general square matrix

Let $A = [a_{ij}]$ be an $n \times n$ matrix with $n \geq 4$. Assume determinants have already been defined for $(n - 1) \times (n - 1)$ matrices.

The (i, j) -th minor of A , denoted

$$\text{minor}(A)_{ij},$$

is the determinant of the $(n - 1) \times (n - 1)$ matrix obtained from A by deleting row i and column j .

The (i, j) -cofactor of A is

$$\text{cof}(A)_{ij} = (-1)^{i+j} \text{minor}(A)_{ij}.$$

The determinant of A is defined by expansion along the first row:

$$\det(A) = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{1j} \text{cof}(A)_{1j}.$$

Fact

For an $n \times n$ matrix, cofactor expansion along any row or any column gives the same determinant:

$$\det(A) = \sum_{j=1}^n a_{ij} \text{cof}(A)_{ij}$$

for any fixed row i , and

$$\det(A) = \sum_{i=1}^n a_{ij} \text{cof}(A)_{ij}$$

for any fixed column j .

Activity

Calculate the determinant of the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 & 4 \\ 5 & 4 & 2 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 4 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 & 3 & 2 \end{bmatrix}$$

Expand along column 3:

$$\det(A) = 3 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{13} + 2 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{23} \\ + 4 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{33} + 3 \operatorname{cof}(A)_{43}.$$

The signs in column 3 are

$$+, -, +, -.$$

So

$$\begin{aligned}
 \det(A) = & 3 \det \begin{bmatrix} 5 & 4 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 & 2 \end{bmatrix} \\
 & - 2 \det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 4 \\ 1 & 3 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 & 2 \end{bmatrix} \\
 & + 4 \det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 4 \\ 5 & 4 & 3 \\ 3 & 4 & 2 \end{bmatrix} \\
 & - 3 \det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 4 \\ 5 & 4 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 5 \end{bmatrix}.
 \end{aligned}$$

Using the 3×3 determinant method,

$$\det \begin{bmatrix} 5 & 4 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 & 2 \end{bmatrix} = -33,$$

$$\det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 4 \\ 1 & 3 & 5 \\ 3 & 4 & 2 \end{bmatrix} = -8,$$

$$\det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 4 \\ 5 & 4 & 3 \\ 3 & 4 & 2 \end{bmatrix} = 26,$$

and

$$\det \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 4 \\ 5 & 4 & 3 \\ 1 & 3 & 5 \end{bmatrix} = 11.$$

Therefore

$$\begin{aligned} \det(A) &= 3(-33) - 2(-8) + 4(26) - 3(11) \\ &= -99 + 16 + 104 - 33 \\ &= -12. \end{aligned}$$

Activity

Compute $\det(A)$, where

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 2 & 3 & 4 \\ 0 & 4 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 5 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Expanding in cofactors along column 1 (because most of the entries of that column are zeros), we find

$$\begin{aligned}\det(A) &= 3 \cdot \text{cof}(A)_{11} + 0 \cdot \text{cof}(A)_{21} \\ &\quad + 0 \cdot \text{cof}(A)_{31} + 0 \cdot \text{cof}(A)_{41} \\ &= 3(-1)^{1+1} \det \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 2 & 5 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= 3 \det \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 2 & 5 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix}\end{aligned}$$

Expanding along the first column again, we find that

$$\begin{aligned}\det \begin{bmatrix} 4 & 2 & 3 \\ 0 & 2 & 5 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix} &= 4 \det \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 5 \\ 0 & -1 \end{bmatrix} \\ &= 4((2)(-1) - (5)(0)) = -8.\end{aligned}$$

So $\det(A) = (3)(-8) = -24$.

Recall Main diagonal.

Definition: Triangular and Diagonal Matrices

An $n \times n$ matrix $A = [a_{ij}]$ is called

upper triangular

if $a_{ij} = 0$ for $i > j$, and

lower triangular

if $a_{ij} = 0$ for $i < j$. A matrix is

diagonal

if it is both upper triangular and lower triangular, i.e., if $a_{ij} = 0$ for $i \neq j$. We denote the $n \times n$ diagonal matrix with entries $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n$ on the diagonal by $\text{diag}(\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n)$.

Theorem

If $A = [a_{ij}]$ is a upper or lower triangular matrix, then $\det(A) = a_{11} \cdots a_{nn}$. That is, the determinant of a triangular matrix is the product of entries in the *main diagonal*.

Why is this true?

A generalization of the argument used to calculate the activity, i.e., expanding the determinant in cofactors along the first column iteratively.

Theorem

If a row or column of a matrix A consists entirely of zeros, then $\det(A) = 0$.

Why is this true?

A generalization of the argument used to calculate the determinant in the activity.

Theorem

If a matrix B is obtained from a matrix A by swapping two rows or two columns, then $\det(B) = -\det(A)$.

Activity

Check directly that the theorem is true when A and B are 2×2 matrices.

Why is this true?

If

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$$

and

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} c & d \\ a & b \end{bmatrix},$$

then $\det(A) = ad - bc$ and $\det(B) = cb - ad = -(ad - bc) = -\det(A)$.

Theorem

If two rows (or columns) of A are equal to one another, then $\det(A) = 0$.

Why is this true?

Let B be obtained by swapping the two identical rows (or columns) of A . Then $A = B$, and the theorem implies that $\det(A) = -\det(B) = -\det(A)$. Therefore $2 \det(A) = 0$, and thus that $\det(A) = 0$.

Theorem

If B is obtained from A by multiplying each entry in a row or column of A by a quantity k , then $\det(B) = k \det(A)$.

Why is this true?

Suppose that B is obtained from A by multiplying each entry of row i by k . Consider a cofactor expansion along row i of B . Then

$$\begin{aligned}
\det(B) &= ka_{i1}\text{cof}(B)_{i1} + ka_{i2}\text{cof}(B)_{i2} + \cdots + ka_{in}\text{cof}(B)_{in} \\
&= k[a_{i1}\text{cof}(A)_{i1} + \cdots + a_{in}\text{cof}(A)_{in}] \\
&= k\det(A).
\end{aligned}$$

Fact

If A is a $n \times n$ matrix, then $\det(kA) = k^n \det(A)$.

Theorem

If B is obtained by adding k times the i th row of A to the j th row, for $i \neq j$, which is a row operation which we denote by $R_j \rightarrow R_j + kR_i$, then $\det(B) = \det(A)$.

We can check the theorem in the 2×2 case. If

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{bmatrix}$$

and

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} a & b \\ c + ka & d + kb \end{bmatrix},$$

then

$$\det(A) = ad - bc$$

and

$$\begin{aligned}
\det(B) &= a(d + kb) - b(c + ka) \\
&= ad + kab - bc - kab \\
&= ad - bc = \det(A).
\end{aligned}$$

Theorem: How row operations affect the determinant

Here is a summary of how the elementary row operations, when applied to a matrix, affect the determinant:

- $R_i \rightarrow kR_i$ multiplies the determinant by k .
- $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$ multiplies the determinant by -1 .
- $R_j \rightarrow R_j + kR_i$ leaves the determinant unchanged.

Activity

Suppose a matrix B is obtained from a matrix A by applying the following row operations:

- $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$
- $R_4 \rightarrow 4R_4$
- $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + 3R_2$

If $\det(A) = 8$, what is the determinant of B .

- $R_i \leftrightarrow R_j$ multiplies the determinant by -1 .
- $R_4 \rightarrow 4R_4$ multiplies the determinant by 4.
- $R_3 \rightarrow R_3 + 3R_2$ does not change the determinant.

Therefore $\det(B) = (-1)(4) \det(A) = -32$.

Activity

Compute the determinant of the matrix

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ -1 & 3 & 3 \\ 0 & 15 & 12 \end{bmatrix}.$$

We use the elementary row operations to make the matrix B triangular:

$$R_2 \rightarrow R_2 + R_1$$

$$\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 5 & 4 \\ 0 & 15 & 12 \end{bmatrix}$$

$$R_3 \rightarrow R_3 - 3R_2$$

$$\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 5 & 4 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

None of the row operations we have performed change the determinant of the matrix, and the final matrix has determinant zero, so $\det(B) = 0$.

Theorem

If A and B are $n \times n$ matrices, then $\det(AB) = \det(A) \det(B)$.

Activity

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ -2 & 7 \end{bmatrix} \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 \end{bmatrix} \quad C = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 4 \\ 0 & 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Compute the determinant of A , B , and C .

We use the formula for 2×2 matrices: First, that

$$\det(A) = (3)(7) - (1)(-2) = 23,$$

then that

$$\det(B) = (1)(4) - (2)(2) = 0,$$

and that

$$\det(C) = (1)(2) - (4)(0) = 2.$$

Activity

Let

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 1 \\ -2 & 7 \end{bmatrix} \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 2 & 4 \end{bmatrix} \quad C = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 4 \\ 0 & 2 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Activity (continued)

Compute the determinant of AC and BC .

Using the theorem, we calculate that

$$\det(AC) = \det(A) \det(C) = (23)(2) = 46,$$

and that

$$\det(BC) = \det(B) \det(C) = (0)(2) = 0.$$

Alternatively, we can calculate the products of the matrices, i.e., that

$$AC = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 14 \\ -2 & 6 \end{bmatrix}$$

and that

$$BC = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 8 \\ 2 & 16 \end{bmatrix},$$

and calculate the determinants directly.

Theorem

If A is a $n \times n$ matrix, then A is *nonsingular* if and only if $\det(A) \neq 0$. In this case $\det(A^{-1}) = 1/\det(A)$.

Why is this true?

We prove only one direction of the theorem, that if A is nonsingular then $\det(A) \neq 0$ and $\det(A^{-1}) = 1/\det(A)$. Suppose that A is non-singular. Then $AA^{-1} = I$. Taking determinants of both sides, and using that I is diagonal, so that $\det(I) = 1$, we see that

$$1 = \det(I) = \det(AA^{-1}) = \det(A)\det(A^{-1}).$$

Thus $\det(A) \neq 0$ (since otherwise the right hand side of this equation would be zero), and rearranging gives $\det(A^{-1}) = 1/\det(A)$.

Theorem

If A is a square matrix, then $\det(A) = \det(A^T)$.

Definition: Orthogonal Matrices

A square matrix A is orthogonal if $A^T = A^{-1}$.

Activity

If A is an orthogonal matrix, what are the possible values of $\det(A)$?

If A is orthogonal, then applying the determinant to both sides of the equation $I = AA^T$ gives

$$\begin{aligned} 1 &= \det(I) = \det(AA^T) \\ &= \det(A) \det(A^T) = \det(A)^2. \end{aligned}$$

Taking square roots gives that $\det(A) = \pm 1$.